Funnies

Pip & Otto at ten · Letters to the floe

PIP & OTTO · Sunday on the floe



Inside: Pip & Otto turn ten. Ines Barlow on a decade of croissants, fish and one bow tie.

Letters to the floe: your questions, Otto's answers. Both on page 2.

Next Sunday: Otto learns to skate.

Ten winters on the floe

By Ruth Okafor · Arts reporter

Ines Barlow draws a penguin and a walrus every weekday morning at a kitchen table in Saltmarsh Lane, and she has done it for ten years. *Pip & Otto* first ran in the Despatch on 17 October 2016, squeezed under the crossword. It now runs in eleven papers, in six languages, and it still fits in four square panels.

"The rule is that the joke has to land in the fourth panel and not before," Barlow says. "If Otto is funny in panel two, I've wasted the strip." Pip is small, polite and always hungry. Otto runs a bakery on an ice floe, wears a bow tie to work and has never once given a straight answer. Readers write to both of them. Most of the letters are addressed to Otto.

Barlow grew up over her parents' bakery in Harrow Road, which accounts for the croissants. The penguin came later, from a postcard her grandmother sent from Cape Town. "I drew Pip on the back of an order book when I was nine. He had the scarf already. Otto took me another twenty years."

She sent the first six strips to the Despatch in the summer of 2016, with a covering letter of one line. The comics editor at the time, Martin Fry, ran them as a trial for a month. The trial has not ended. Fry, now retired, still gets the strip a day early by post. "He tells me when a joke is weak," Barlow says. "He is usually right."

The work starts on Monday with five pencil roughs on sheets of A4, four boxes to a sheet. By Wednesday they are inked and coloured. The pictures go to the paper with no words in them; the words go separately, as a short script: who speaks, in which panel, and what they say. A sound effect gets a line of its own.

That habit started with the French edition in 2019. "Lettering a strip twice by hand was a week's work," she says. "Now each paper sets the words in its own language, and the balloons are drawn round them." The Spanish papers get *¡Recién salido del horno!*; the Japanese edition stands its balloons in vertical columns and reads the panels from right to left, as the Arabic one does. The pictures never change.

The Sunday strip is the exception to the four-panel rule. It takes half a page, in colour, and Barlow treats it as a short story: three panels, a slower joke, and usually a fish. This week's is on the cover.

What is next for the pair? "Otto is going to learn to skate," Barlow says. "He will not enjoy it."

Pip & Otto in numbers

2,516 daily strips since October 2016. **520** Sunday half pages. **11** newspapers, **6** languages. **1** bow tie.

Letters to the floe

Dear Otto, my son wants to know why a walrus needs a bow tie. — *Grace, Abbotsford*

Otto replies: A baker who does not dress for work bakes flat bread.

Dear Pip, have you ever finished a whole croissant? — *Tomasz, aged 8, Riverside*

Pip replies: Once. It took two days and Otto charged me twice.

Dear Otto, is the bakery on the floe a real place? I would like to visit. — *Mrs D. Keane, Harrow*

Otto replies: Yes. It moves about. Bring a coat.

Dear Ines Barlow, will Pip ever grow? — *Sam, Brook Lane*

Ines Barlow replies: He grows a little each winter. He does not notice. Write to Pip and Otto at the Despatch, 12 Bridge Street, Corrington, or by email. Letters may be shortened.

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Ten Winters on the Floe. Every Pip & Otto Sunday strip from the first ten years, in one book. 240 pages in colour, £18 from the Despatch shop and every good bookseller.

Set in Newsreader and Archivo Narrow; lettered in Comic Neue and Bangers (SIL OFL). Pictures generated with diffusion models.

